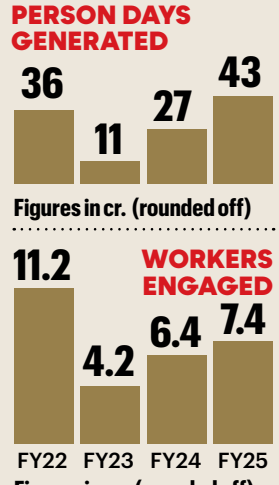


SO LITTLE TO DO

After 2021-22, Bengal struggled to get NREGA work going



Source: West Bengal govt

O NREGA FAMINE

irregularities, Bengal has managed to create only 809.6 million person days—barely double the 364.3 million achieved in a single 'normal' year just before. Indeed, in FY22, it was also able to give work to 11.2 million individuals.

NEGLECT VS ACCOUNTABILITY

There's a silver lining: under state financing, in FY25, the number of person days generated—which refers to the total number of days of work individuals were engaged in—has crossed FY22 numbers to hit 429.2 million (see graphic, *So Little to Do*). But this slight progress hardly addresses the financial famine caused by New Delhi's pause, for Bengal employed only some 7.4 million workers in NREGA work last year. What this means is that the base of the scheme has become smaller (there are less projects now), although more work days are being generated. It also means the benefits are reaching fewer people.

Repeated appeals by the state to the Centre for release of funds have failed. Bengal's Trinamool Congress regime ascribes political motives; the BJP-led Centre insists it's enforcing accountability. The 2022 freeze had followed allegations of corruption and procedural lapses, especially in Purba Bardhaman, Hooghly, Malda and Darjeeling. This April, the Calcutta High Court said an indefinite suspension was not justified, and asked the Centre why NREGA funds shouldn't resume for the rest of the state, excluding those districts. Earlier this year, a meeting between Bengal's panchayat minister Pradip Mazumdar and his counterpart in the Union cabinet, Shivraj Chouhan, was abruptly postponed by the latter's office. The last minister-level meeting was in November 2022. The prolonged deadlock has paralysed welfare delivery in rural Bengal.

Takeaways

- **After FY22, Bengal has had to self-finance NREGA work. The Centre has 'paused' funds, alleging irregularities**
- **Person days created were 364.3 mn in FY22; 809.6 mn in the next 3 years together**
- **Cash-strapped Bengal has imposed strict austerity to clear unpaid central dues**

The issue acquires renewed urgency as the state approaches a critical election year. Prime Minister Narendra Modi, at a recent rally in Alipurduar, accused the TMC regime of stalling development projects and perpetuating corruption. In a riposte, the TMC cited unpaid NREGA and Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana (PMAY) dues as evidence of deliberate central neglect. The TMC had sailed through the 2024 Lok Sabha election on that narrative. But the deprived masses largely remain where they were.

According to Nabanna, Bengal's administrative HQ, people are still awaiting NREGA payment for work completed up to December 2021. Wage arrears alone amount to Rs 3,732 crore. Add material, contractors, administrative costs, and the total dues reach Rs 6,907 crore. The state has cleared the due wages from its own budget. It has also begun clearing PMAY dues on its own—much the better to invest in a narrative.

The attendant fiscal pressure has led the state finance department to impose strict austerity measures. No new development project to be sanctioned in the foreseeable future, and government expenditure above Rs 10 lakh needs special clearance. All that is only band-aid on a gaping institutional wound. ■